DEMO INSTITUTION

Institutional Enrolment and Capacity Planning Policy

Policy period: 2020–2026

Policy reference: IMC / ENR / 2026–01

Issue date: 1 October 2026

Policy owner: Office of Institutional Planning

Approving authority: Institutional Management Committee (IMC)

Next scheduled review: September 2027

Applies to: Undergraduate enrolment planning and capacity decisions

FICTIONAL SAMPLE — NOT A REAL UNIVERSITY POLICY

All institutions, figures, approvals, dates and committee records in this document are invented for a demonstration scenario. This policy has no legal or operational authority outside that scenario.

1. Policy statement and scope

1.1 Purpose

The Demo Institution shall plan undergraduate enrolment in a manner that safeguards the quality of teaching, student welfare, learning facilities and financial sustainability. Annual planning decisions shall use verified enrolment records, documented programme capacity assessments and a formal management approval process. The institution recognises that future headcounts may differ from planning estimates and requires decisions to take account of that uncertainty.

Enrolment planning shall support the institution's academic mission rather than setting intake objectives without regard to instructional capacity. No office may treat an indicative enrolment target, planning projection or pending proposal as authority to exceed the latest formally approved operating capacity.

1.2 Applicability

This policy applies to the Admissions Office, Office of Institutional Planning, Registry, Finance Office, Academic Deans, Student Affairs, Facilities Directorate and all academic units that submit undergraduate intake proposals. Programme-level requirements set by relevant academic or regulatory bodies continue to apply even where the institution-wide capacity is higher.

This policy does not approve new buildings, authorise financial expenditure, substitute for programme accreditation, or vary occupational safety obligations. Separate authorisations remain necessary for each of those matters.

1.3 Planning terms

Approved operating capacity means the maximum undergraduate headcount authorised for a specified academic year by the Institutional Management Committee after consideration of academic and physical resources. An indicative enrolment target is an internal planning objective and may be revised. A planning forecast is an estimate of future headcount based on information available at the time. Recorded enrolment is the verified student headcount for a defined reporting period. These quantities must be labelled separately in all reports.

2. Policy governance and responsibilities

2.1 Institutional Management Committee

The Institutional Management Committee is the final internal authority for changes to the institution-wide undergraduate operating capacity within this fictional policy framework. It reviews proposals, requests further evidence when necessary, approves or rejects revisions, and records the effective date and any conditions. A decision is not effective solely because it was discussed at a meeting or included in a draft budget.

2.2 Office of Institutional Planning

The Office of Institutional Planning coordinates the annual enrolment planning process, maintains the capacity register, consolidates forecasts and targets from academic units, and prepares reports for management. It must identify the reporting year, the relevant student population and the dated decision supporting each quoted capacity limit. Any disagreement between records must be referred to the Registry and the office that issued the approval.

2.3 Admissions, Registry and academic units

The Admissions Office proposes intake volumes consistent with authorised limits and programme constraints. The Registry verifies recorded headcounts and defines whether figures include continuing students, returning students and approved deferrals. Academic units report teaching loads, available laboratory places, placement

opportunities, programme restrictions and anticipated resource shortfalls. No single unit may independently revise the institution-wide capacity register.

2.4 Finance, Facilities and Student Affairs

Finance assesses the affordability of staffing, maintenance and proposed expansion. Facilities provides verified room capacities, timetable usage and safety constraints. Student Affairs considers student support services, accessibility needs and welfare implications. Their written assessments shall accompany any material request to increase student numbers.

3. Annual planning cycle

3.1 Calendar and submissions

By the end of February, the Registry shall submit the verified prior-year undergraduate headcount and document the reporting date. By the end of March, each academic unit shall provide a proposed intake plan and a statement of programme constraints. By the end of April, the Office of Institutional Planning shall consolidate the institutional planning outlook and identify any projected pressure on approved capacity. By the end of May, Finance, Facilities and Student Affairs shall submit their resource assessments.

A draft planning recommendation shall be considered by the Institutional Planning Working Group in June. Where a change to approved capacity is proposed, the committee submission shall include the supporting assessments and intended effective year. Until the Institutional Management Committee issues an approved decision, the latest recorded capacity remains in force.

3.2 Information quality

Annual headcounts must be traceable to Registry records and use consistent population definitions. Missing reporting periods, duplicate records and material changes in counting methods shall be disclosed before planning estimates are used. Where a department disputes a figure, the original record and a written reconciliation shall be retained. Staff must not silently substitute an earlier estimate for a verified later figure.

3.3 Planning scenarios

The annual review may examine a base case, a lower-intake case and a higher-intake case to understand the effects on staffing and facilities. These scenarios guide discussion; they are not admission instructions. Where a proposed target is above the authorised operating limit, the Admissions Office shall prepare a compliant alternative pending a formal capacity decision.

4. Capacity approvals and policy history, 2020–2026

4.1 Historical capacity record

For 2020, the fictional approved undergraduate operating capacity was 1,400 students. The annual planning process introduced a common capacity statement for the institution.

For 2021, the fictional approved undergraduate operating capacity was 1,500 students. The year’s review strengthened the Registry’s responsibility for consistent headcount reporting.

For 2022, the fictional approved undergraduate operating capacity was 1,600 students. The 2022 revision required programme-level teaching, laboratory and placement assessments before a capacity increase could be recommended. The revised rule became effective on 1 July 2022.

For 2023, the fictional approved undergraduate operating capacity was 1,650 students. The 2023 revision formalised escalation when the reported or anticipated headcount exceeded the operating limit.

For 2024, the fictional approved undergraduate operating capacity was 1,700 students. The 2024 review introduced a consolidated readiness statement covering teaching rooms, staff availability and student services.

For 2025, the fictional approved undergraduate operating capacity was 1,800 students. The fictional Registry recorded 1,815 undergraduates at the stated 2025 reporting point; management required a review of the variance and measures to safeguard services. The recorded 1,815 does not itself amend the approved 1,800 limit.

4.2 Current 2026 capacity and pending proposal

For 2026, the approved undergraduate operating capacity remains 1,800 students. A proposal was submitted to increase the 2026 operating capacity to 2,000 students, subject to classroom availability, teaching appointments, student-service readiness and a financing review. As of the issue date of this document, the Institutional Management Committee has NOT approved the proposed increase to 2,000 students.

The working group may consider the 2,000-student proposal for scenario planning, but no admissions notice or operational plan may describe it as an approved limit. Any later approval must be recorded in a signed decision with a new effective date before this policy record is updated.

4.3 Status of earlier approvals

The historical numbers above describe the limit approved for their respective years; they are not cumulative entitlements and may not be used interchangeably with the 2026 limit. When checking a capacity statement, staff shall identify the relevant year and its approval status. Draft minutes, proposed budgets and working group recommendations shall not be recorded as adopted decisions.

5. Enrolment targets and resource readiness

5.1 Target-setting principles

Targets shall be based on programme plans, verified continuing-student expectations, anticipated completions and the availability of teaching and student-support resources. Each target statement shall identify its year and whether it is proposed, adopted or superseded. A numerical target may be lower than the approved maximum to preserve flexibility for returning students and programme-specific constraints.

5.2 Indicative targets by year

The fictional planning record shows an indicative undergraduate target of 1,700 for 2024 and 1,750 for 2025. For 2026, the working group discussed an aspirational undergraduate headcount target of 1,900. This 2026 target is provisional, not formally adopted and does not authorise enrolment beyond the approved capacity of 1,800. The 2026 proposed target of 1,900 and proposed capacity increase to 2,000 are separate matters and require separate decisions.

5.3 Teaching and facilities readiness

Before proposing additional intake, academic units shall document teaching contact hours, reasonable class sizes, laboratory or studio places, library access, programme supervision and any placements required for professional practice. Facilities shall provide a dated review of classrooms, lecture venues, accessibility arrangements and safe occupancy. An available room is not necessarily suitable for a specialised programme.

Where expansion depends on new accommodation or staffing, the proposal must distinguish resources that are funded and available from resources that are planned but not yet delivered. Proposed facilities or recruitment shall not be counted as operationally available until verified.

5.4 Student support and affordability

Student Affairs shall review accommodation guidance where relevant, advising capacity, health and wellbeing provision, access arrangements and student complaints. Finance shall identify the recurring costs of any

additional enrolment and the risk of reliance on income that has not yet materialised. The planning recommendation shall include any conditions needed to maintain acceptable service standards.

6. Procedure where enrolment may exceed capacity

6.1 Monitoring and escalation

A variance review is required when a verified headcount exceeds the approved operating capacity or when a reliable planning estimate indicates a material risk of exceedance. The Office of Institutional Planning shall notify the Registrar, Admissions Office and relevant academic leadership and open a documented review. The initial review should state the year, reporting definition, approved limit, estimated or recorded headcount and any immediate programme-specific restrictions.

A headcount above the approved limit shall not be interpreted as proof that additional classrooms are necessary. The cause and distribution of the variance must first be established; options may include revised timetables, improved room allocation, alternative teaching arrangements consistent with academic standards, controlled admissions schedules or a formally assessed expansion proposal.

6.2 Capacity expansion request

A request to increase capacity must include the proposed new limit and effective year; Registry data supporting the need; academic-unit readiness statements; verified facilities and safety checks; a student-support assessment; a financial statement; and any accreditation or external approval requirements. The Office of Institutional Planning shall maintain a record of the proposal's status throughout review.

The Institutional Management Committee may approve, approve subject to conditions, defer or reject a request. Only a documented decision authorises a new institution-wide limit. A deferred application continues to be treated as pending, regardless of how likely staff believe approval may be.

6.3 Interim controls

While a capacity request remains pending, the Admissions Office shall use the currently approved limit for new intake decisions. The Registrar shall report any existing variance and its effect on programme services. Additional enrolment commitments require a separate documented authority consistent with institutional and regulatory obligations. Neither an informal recommendation nor a forecast is such authority.

7. Policy interpretation, records and accountability

7.1 Record of decisions

The Office of Institutional Planning shall maintain the capacity register, including approval date, academic year, approved figure, conditions, authorising body and supporting references. Superseded registers shall be retained with clear version dates. For every capacity increase, the relevant signed committee resolution must be available to the authorised staff who maintain the register.

Planning papers and committee decisions shall distinguish facts drawn from approved records from opinions, scenarios and recommendations. If a document lacks evidence for a requested matter, staff shall seek the responsible office's record rather than assume an answer.

7.2 Contradictions and missing records

If two documents appear to give different limits for the same year, the Office of Institutional Planning shall confirm which record was valid on the relevant date. The existence of a later proposal does not automatically supersede an earlier approval. Missing committee minutes, unsigned memoranda or incomplete resource assessments shall be flagged before a decision is represented as final.

Where no approved information is available, a report should state that the matter is not established by the available records. Silence in this policy does not constitute approval. Matters outside undergraduate enrolment planning, including campus construction permissions, are addressed under other applicable institutional procedures and are not determined by this policy.

7.3 Confidentiality and access

Student-level records may be handled only by authorised personnel and shall be shared on a need-to-know basis. General planning reports should use aggregated information wherever possible. The Registry and academic units are responsible for checking that information supplied for management consideration does not disclose unnecessary personal information.

7.4 Review and amendment

The policy owner shall review this document annually and earlier if a material institutional or regulatory change occurs. Revisions require a dated revision notice, the reason for change and the applicable approval. Staff must use the current authorised version for operational decisions while retaining superseded versions for audit purposes.

8. Revision history and reference summary

8.1 Annual policy revisions

2020: Annual institution-wide enrolment planning cycle introduced; approved capacity 1,400.

2021: Headcount reporting and record consistency requirements strengthened; approved capacity 1,500.

2022: Programme-level resource assessment made mandatory for proposed capacity increases; approved capacity 1,600.

2023: Escalation procedure for projected or recorded capacity pressure adopted; approved capacity 1,650.

2024: Consolidated teaching, facilities and student-support readiness review introduced; approved capacity 1,700.

2025: Management review triggered by recorded headcount of 1,815 against approved capacity of 1,800; no automatic revision of capacity.

2026: Approved capacity remains 1,800; proposal to raise capacity to 2,000 is pending and not approved as of 1 October 2026.

8.2 Current policy interpretation

For all undergraduate enrolment planning decisions made under this fictional 2026 policy, use 1,800 students as the currently approved institution-wide operating capacity unless a subsequent signed decision states otherwise. The proposed 2,000-student capacity and the provisional 1,900-student target remain unapproved planning matters. Academic programme limits and other applicable restrictions may impose lower effective ceilings.

Questions about the approval status of a proposal shall be resolved against the dated committee decision register. Planning staff shall not infer permission from a proposal, a target, a historical limit or a projected future headcount.